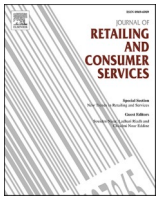
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Fun or warm: How conversational style boosts customer engagement

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ABSTRACT

This research proposes and shows that a fun conversational style fosters greater tourist engagement than chatbots' traditional warm conversational style in a hotel room booking context. Furthermore, successful technology adoption requires businesses to understand the influence of cultural factors. Specifically, comprehending how individualism, a key cultural factor, shapes the effectiveness of chatbot conversation styles is important to enhance tourist engagement. Our findings, across two studies employing a combination of online surveys (Study 1, n = 241) and a randomised between-subject experiment (Study 2, n = 113), demonstrate that tourists' individualism serves as a boundary condition for the relationship between chatbot conversation styles and engagement. Additionally, results show that a fun chatbot conversation style increases customer engagement through underlying mechanisms of consumer's sense of liberation and hedonic involvement. Our research contributes to the psychological theory of fun and literature related to customer engagement. From a practical standpoint, this research offers valuable insights into the effectiveness of chatbot conversations that resonate with the needs of tourists while booking a hotel room. Marketing firms should deploy fun chatbots that stimulate customers' attention, interest, arousal, and curiosity through enjoyable experiences to foster customer engagement.

1. Introduction

The market is fast transitioning from a passive consumption setting towards a more customer engagement-driven context through experiential service delivery, integration of modern technologies, and service customisation (Hollebeek et al., 2024). Elon Musk of Tesla Automotive Inc. Unveiled GrokAI, a conversational agent that adds a dash of humour to routine conversations, thus making them more engaging (Xie et al., 2024). Similarly, other technology platforms like Google and HuggingFace Chat have deployed chatbots that employ a fun conversational style to generate engagement with potential implications for brands. However, little is known about the effectiveness of fun chatbot conversations in fostering customer engagement. This is crucial to understand as chatbots often fail to provide consumers with engaging conversations that lead to dissatisfaction, anger, and frustration (Crolic et al., 2021; Guo et al., 2025). Moreover, existing literature does not show much evidence of how best to design and deploy a chatbot to foster customer engagement despite calls by the Marketing Science Institute in 2021 and some scholars, such as Aslam (2023). In this research, we argue for a better chatbot design with a novel conversational style to deepen customer engagement.

Some recent articles have investigated whether conversational styles of chatbots engender customer engagement (Li and Wang, 2023). Particularly, these studies have focused on two specific types – warm and competent conversational styles of chatbots (Zhou and Chang, 2024). To this end, our research adds to the narrative on the influence of chatbot conversational styles on customer engagement by including a new conversational style that remains unexplored till date. We contribute by proposing a 'fun' conversational style, a novel approach utilising the lens of the psychological theory of consumer fun (Oh and Pham, 2021) and its impact on customer engagement with brands. Moreover, we retain the warm conversational style introduced in prior research (Choi and Zhou, 2023) in our study.

This research employs the psychological theory of consumer fun (Oh

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and Pham, 2021) to posit that a chatbot with a fun conversational style is characterised by novelty, spontaneity, and social connectedness, which will enable customer engagement with brands. Fun style involves a deep psychological immersion into hedonically engaging conversations, thus promoting positive experiences (Oh and Pham, 2021) and fostering customer engagement (Rohit et al., 2024). This research draws on the tenets of the customer engagement framework to assert that positive experiences emanating from fun conversations can deliver enhanced customer engagement. We further explain the psychological mechanisms of 'consumer's hedonic involvement' and a 'sense of liberation' that underlie the relationship between fun conversational style and customer engagement. Moreover, the role of culture in technology adoption and consumer decision-making remains a topical aspect of marketing research (Nam and Kannan, 2021). Kamoonpuri and Sengar (2023) emphasised the importance of discovering whether the cultural value of individuals influences the adoption of AI and the purchase process. Specifically, we respond to these explicit calls by investigating the moderating role of individualism as a cultural dimension in the influence of fun (vs. warm) conversational chatbot styles on customer engagement. In doing so, we offer key insights into customer segmentation based on culture, which would enable managers to profile customers and, accordingly, develop chatbots to drive customer engagement (Rohit et al., 2024).

Therefore, this research addresses the following three research questions.

RQ1. How do different chatbot conversational styles (fun vs. warm) impact customer engagement? Does a fun conversational style, compared to a warm style, elicit better customer engagement?

RQ2. Do sense of liberation and hedonic involvement explain the underlying mechanism for the impact of chatbot conversational styles on customer engagement?

RQ3. Does consumer individualism moderate the influence of fun (vs warm) chatbot conversational style on customer engagement?

Two studies were conducted to investigate the above research gaps, employing a multi-methods approach. The studies were designed in the tourism context to understand the tourists' behaviour during booking a hotel room. The first study involved an online survey with 241 U.S. respondents recruited through Amazon Mechanical Turk (MTurk). The second study utilised a randomised between-subject experiment with an Indian sample. The responses were collected from 113 tourists who were visiting a pre-selected destination. Across these two studies, our findings revealed that a fun chatbot conversation style significantly increased customer engagement compared to a warm conversation style, hedonic involvement and a sense of liberation had significant indirect effects supporting the proposed psychological mechanism, and customer individualism significantly accentuated the impact of fun conversational style on customer engagement. Thus, this study makes several key contributions to the literature at the intersection of chatbot conversation styles and customer engagement. First, this research addresses an existing gap in the literature; we contribute to the chatbot conversational style discourse by proposing a fun conversational style, a novel approach, while previous research has often centred on warm and competent conversational styles (Kim and Hur, 2023) in driving customer engagement. Second, we uncover the mediating mechanisms of customers' hedonic involvement and a sense of liberation in the fun conversational style-customer engagement relationship. Third, we delve into how individualism, a key cultural dimension, shapes the effectiveness of chatbot conversation styles in fostering customer engagement. This understanding is crucial for businesses to tailor chatbot interactions effectively and build strong customer relationships.

The subsequent sections of this paper are outlined as follows: Section 2 presents a review of the literature about the psychological theory of consumer fun, followed by hypotheses development in section 3. Section 4 details the research methodology, presents the findings and discusses the results. Section 5 offers a broader discussion, examining the theoretical and practical implications of the research. Section 6 addresses the limitations of the studies and outlines potential avenues for future research. Finally, Section 7 presents the conclusion of this research.

2. Literature review

2.1. The psychological theory of consumer fun

Fun is a pleasurable experience marked by subjective feelings of delight, amusement, and light-hearted disposition (Xie et al., 2024). Oh and Pham (2021) explained the psychological underpinnings of fun as an experience utilising their psychological theory of consumer fun. It asserts that the experience of fun is a liberating experience—a hedonically involved activity that provides a momentary escape from psychological restraint (Oh and Pham, 2021). Fun is determined by combining two psychological foundations: hedonic involvement and a sense of liberation. Hedonic involvement refers to a deep absorption in a joyful experience, and a sense of liberation refers to a brief escape from psychological constraints (Oh and Pham, 2021). Thus, fun is a subjective assessment of an individual's experience rooted in personal experience. Previous research has investigated the role of fun in consumer decision-making. Various industries have focused on the engineering of fun to elicit positive consumer behaviour. A key focus of service industries is to design an innovative experience that generates feelings of fun, which benefits the firms (Kol and Lissitsa, 2024). As a result, consumers get immersed and absorbed in the fun experience (Prentice et al., 2020).

Further, equipping chatbots with fun has become a requirement because fun increases the appeal of technological innovations and boosts consumer adoption and customer engagement (Pillai et al., 2024). Extant research investigated several chatbot conversation styles, such as social-oriented vs. task-oriented styles (De Cicco et al., 2020), warm vs. competent styles (El Hedhli et al., 2023; Zhou and Chang, 2024), and formal vs. informal styles (Li and Wang, 2023), among others. Table 1 provides an overview of the various chatbot conversation styles. However, the impact of chatbots' fun conversational style is limited. Fun can be a crucial determinant of customer engagement with brands on digital platforms. For example, when customers have fun on a brand's social media page, they are more likely to engage in brand-beneficial behaviours such as word-of-mouth, continued usage, and loyalty. Fun emanates heightened emotional arousal, and such intense emotions could elicit greater consumer–brand engagement (Prentice et al., 2020; Mishra et al., 2024). Therefore, drawing on the psychological theory of consumer fun, this research suggests that a chatbot with a fun communication style can foster customer engagement with brands.

2.2. Customer engagement

Customer engagement has emerged as a critical business performance indicator in recent years (Moharana et al., 2023a). Engaged customers have shown improved psychological and behavioural outcomes, including increased loyalty and recommendation behaviour, which ultimately offers the business a major competitive edge. Customer engagement is defined as "a motivational state that occurs by virtue of interactive co-creative, [consumer] experiences with a focal agent/object" (Brodie et al., 2011, p. 260). Customer engagement involves a consumer's intrinsically driven, cognitive investment, affective responses, and behavioural activities toward the brand (Hollebeek et al., 2024). When consumers devote their mental energy to brand (or brand-related items, such as chatbots) activities, like information processing and decision-making, they are cognitively engaged with the brand. Additionally, customers are affectively engaged with a brand when they find brand-related interactions interesting, and they are behaviourally engaged with a brand by sharing, co-creating, and promoting it (Roy Bhattacharjee et al., 2023). Customer engagement is an

Table 1
Overview of studies that focus on chatbot conversational styles.

Study	Key dimensions examined	Outcome	Theory	Findings
De Cicco et al. (2020)	Chatbot interaction style (social-oriented vs. Task-oriented)	Social presence, Trust, Perceived enjoyment, attitude towards chatbot	Social presence theory	Applying a social-oriented interaction style significantly increases users' perception of social presence, positively influencing trust and overall attitude towards the chatbot.
Roy and Naidoo (2021)	Anthropomorphic conversation Style (Warm vs. Competent)	Brand attitude, Purchase intention	Social judgment theory	Chatbots can be given human qualities like warmth and competence to enhance positive consumer experiences.
Kull et al. (2021)	Chatbot message (Warm vs. Competent)	Brand engagement	Social response theory	When chatbots initiate a conversation using a warm (vs. competent) message, brand engagement increases.
El Hedhli et al. (2023)	Virtual influencer's anthropomorphic conversation style (Warm vs. Competent)	Willingness to follow instructions, Purchase intentions	Stereotype content model	Perceived warmth demonstrated a stronger positive association with consumers' willingness to follow the virtual influencer's recommendations compared to perceived competence.
Choi and Zhou (2023)	Chatbot interaction style (Warm vs. Competent), Regulatory focus of consumer	Trust, Willingness to self-disclosure	Stereotype content model and regulatory focus theory	Warmth in chatbot interactions elicits greater self-disclosure from promotion-focused consumers, whereas competence elicits greater self-disclosure from prevention-focused consumers.
Kim and Hur (2023)	Personalisation, Anthropomorphism, Perceived warmth, competence, and empathy	Willingness to use chatbots	Technology acceptance model	Human-like chatbots that personalise interactions are more likely to be adopted, as users perceive them as competent and warm, fostering empathy and increasing their willingness to engage.
Xu et al. (2023)	Conversational cues of a chatbot (Task vs. Social-oriented), temporal cues, perceived warmth, and competence	Satisfaction	Stereotype content model, compensation effect, and cognitive-affective personality	Perceived warmth and competence mediated the effects of temporal and conversational cues on satisfaction.
Janson (2023)	Anthropomorphic design elements, Social orientation of communication style	Satisfaction, trust and empathy toward a chatbot	Social presence theory	Anthropomorphic design and socially oriented communication in chatbots enhance social presence, cultivating trust, empathy, and user satisfaction.
Li and Wang (2023)	Chatbot interaction style (Formal vs. Informal)	Continuance usage intention, Brand attitude	Social response theory, parasocial interaction theory	Informal chatbot interaction styles positively influence chatbot continuance usage intention and brand attitude, with parasocial interaction mediating this relationship.
This study	**Chatbot conversational style (Fun vs. Warm)**	**Sense of liberation, Hedonic involvement, Customer Engagement**	**Psychological theory of consumer fun**	**A fun chatbot conversation style increases customer engagement through underlying mechanisms of the consumer's sense of liberation and hedonic involvement.**

interactive process that revolves around customers' interactions with a brand or specific brand-related entities, such as AI-powered chatbots (Hollebeek et al., 2024). In a hotel room booking context, chatbots can be considered as actors in the engagement process that aids customers in their decision-making. Therefore, this research investigates tourists' engagement while booking a hotel room through chatbots.

3. Hypotheses development

3.1. Fun and warm chatbot conversation style

Fun is an individual's subjective experience involving positive hedonic valence and high arousal (Reis et al., 2016). The psychological theory of consumer fun (Oh and Pham, 2021) indicates that the experience of fun is often centred on transient emotions of being connected with others in a specific situation. Sentiments of togetherness with others heighten consumers' immersive fun with the consumption activity (Kim and Song, 2020). Due to humans' intrinsic need to belong, the congruence of their beliefs, and the affect contagion, hedonic experiences are frequently enjoyed in the company of others, and this social influence frames shared experiences (Moharana et al., 2023b). The psychological theory of consumer fun (Oh and Pham, 2021) posits the importance of novelty, spontaneity, and social connectedness to induce fun experiences with positive outcomes for the firm. Using novel robotics in the service delivery process underscores the possibilities of advancing technologies as a competitive edge (Habib et al., 2025). In an interview with hotel managers, Choi and Choi (2018) discovered that consumers become more immersed with service robots when they perceive it to be an "interesting experience", "novel", and "fun", and therefore, satisfied with the hotel. Also, employing chatbots that are spontaneous helps provide immediate feedback based on a consumer's input; they are considered fun and interesting (Pillai et al., 2024). Thus, we expect that a fun chatbot conversation will lead individuals to cognitively, affectively, and behaviourally engage with the brand because of the fun experiences with the chatbot. This leads us to the first hypothesis.

H1a. A fun chatbot conversational style positively impacts customer engagement.

Warmth is associated with sentiments of admiration, approach tendencies, and higher interpersonal skills such as conscientiousness, good gestures, pleasant facial expressions, and friendly and social expressions (Jiménez-Barreto et al., 2023). Customers associate warmth with brands prioritising customer focus, friendliness, and sociability (Lu and Zhang, 2025). Customers grasp perceptions of warmth, resulting in stronger emotional and behavioural reactions (Kull et al., 2021). Warmth in service interactions is usually linked to a variety of good nonverbal behaviours, including smiling, making greeting gestures, being approachable, and having a positive conversation (Zhou and Chang, 2024). When chatbots balance warmth and concrete responses, they evoke positive sensory, intellectual, affective, behavioural, and social experiences, fostering stronger consumer-brand connections (Jiménez-Barreto et al., 2021; Molinillo et al., 2023). Moreover, a brand's perceived warmth—reflected in its customer-oriented focus, sociability, and friendliness—enhances emotional and behavioural reactions among consumers, as warm service interactions increase customers' sense of being valued and understood (Guo et al., 2025; Jiménez-Barreto et al., 2023). Therefore, customers tend to perceive value in such warm and empathetic service agents and choose to engage with them (Belanche et al., 2021). This follows our next hypothesis.

H1b. A warm chatbot conversational style positively impacts customer engagement.

Fun is a hedonic experience characterised by playfulness and enjoyment, which creates a positive affect and encourages consumers to

immerse themselves in interactions (Oh and Pham, 2021). Unlike traditional service delivery mechanisms, chatbots with a fun conversational style can evoke emotions of delight and curiosity, turning routine transactional interactions into enjoyable and memorable experiences (Wenzel and Benkenstein, 2018). In the context of hospitality, where emotional engagement and experiential value are critical, fun conversational styles have the potential to outperform warm conversational styles in fostering stronger customer relationships. Conversely, warmth is traditionally linked to perceptions of social interaction, care, and friendliness, which are essential attributes for building rapport and reducing uncertainty in customer interactions (Kull et al., 2021; Lu and Zhang, 2025). While warmth emphasises empathetic listening and human-like sociability, its effect may sometimes fall below expectations in highly experiential contexts, such as tourism and hospitality, where consumers increasingly seek novelty and entertainment (Habib et al., 2025). Fun experiences from technological use cause customers to become cognitively absorbed (Oh and Pham, 2021). Humour can break down psychological barriers, increase consumers' openness to recommendations, and create a sense of connectedness with the chatbots (Jiménez-Barreto et al., 2023). By incorporating witty replies, casual tones, and entertaining prompts, fun chatbots create a sense of delight and spontaneity than warm chatbots, which induce consumers more willing to interact, explore, and ultimately engage with the brand (Molinillo et al., 2023). Thus, we hypothesise.

H1c. A fun chatbot conversation style generates greater customer engagement than a warm chatbot conversation style.

3.2. Mediation by the sense of liberation

A sensation of liberation, a feeling of unrestricted and carefree, is a fundamental psychological mechanism underlying fun experiences (Oh and Pham, 2021). A person's sense of liberation is a momentary escape from various internalised common life restraints (Oh and Pham, 2021). People use virtual environments to escape from the restraints of worldly activities (Li et al., 2019). According to the liberating engagement premise, fun experiences engender a sense of relief and liberty (Oh and Pham, 2021). Therefore, the consumer's sense of liberation might be the underlying mechanism that fosters customer brand engagement through a fun chatbot discussion. If chatbot interactions are characterised as a "break" from the ordinary, they may be seen as more fun, leading to customer brand engagement. This is because consumers are increasingly experimenting with information systems and technology to escape reality (Li et al., 2019).

Further, a warm chatbot conversational style, characterised by empathy and friendliness, has fostered trust and emotional connection in customer interactions (Li et al., 2023). These qualities enhance a customer's sense of being understood and valued, which is foundational for customer engagement. A sense of liberation arises when warm chatbot interactions alleviate cognitive and emotional burdens during customer engagements (Oh and Pham, 2021). Warm chatbots, through their personalised and empathetic responses, create an environment that reduces customer stress, making them more willing to engage with the service (Shin et al., 2023; Carvalho and Ivanov, 2024). By fostering an environment where customers feel empowered and cared for, warm chatbots can offer precise and tailored guidance that aligns with customer preferences (Kim et al., 2025). This improves the customer's sense of liberation and enhances their perception of the chatbot as a supportive and reliable service agent. Moreover, customers who experience emotional relief and enhanced autonomy during interactions are more likely to form stronger connections with the brand and exhibit higher engagement (Scarpi, 2024; Shin et al., 2023). Warm chatbot styles foster these feelings by creating a space where customers feel their concerns are heard and addressed, thereby reinforcing their sense of liberation, which, in turn, drives engagement. Hence, we hypothesise.

H2. A sense of liberation positively mediates the relationship between (a) fun and (b) warm chatbot conversation styles and customer engagement.

3.3. Mediation by hedonic involvement

Hedonic involvement refers to the consumer's psychological immersion and engagement in an activity designed for pure enjoyment and emotional gratification (Oh and Pham, 2021). In digital interactions, hedonic involvement plays a pivotal role as people often engage with digital technology to fulfil their hedonic objectives, such as entertainment, playfulness, and social interaction (Li et al., 2023). Fun chatbot styles, characterised by humour, playful language, and engaging interactions, are particularly effective in fostering these hedonic experiences, creating an emotional connection that drives customer engagement. For example, gamified interactions, personalised jokes, or playful use of emojis can immerse customers in the experience, making them feel engaged with the brand while reducing the perceived complexity of the booking process. In a hotel booking context, where the anticipation of pleasurable experiences begins during the planning phase, the ability of a chatbot to engage consumers hedonically is relevant (Chung et al., 2020) because a fun chatbot can transform an otherwise transactional interaction into an enjoyable and exploratory booking experience. This hedonic involvement captures and enhances their emotional investment in the brand, leading to better customer engagement.

Further, warm chatbot interactions evoke positive emotional states by creating a comfortable and enjoyable environment for consumers (Li et al., 2024). For instance, a warm chatbot responding empathetically to a customer's preferences, making personalised travel suggestions, and using friendly language can make the booking experience functional and enjoyable. This pleasurable engagement triggers hedonic involvement, as the consumer feels emotionally immersed in the interaction (Chung et al., 2020). Hedonic involvement facilitates customer engagement by amplifying positive affect and increasing intrinsic motivation. Warm chatbot styles that reduce stress and create emotionally uplifting interactions align with customers' hedonic objectives (Prentice et al., 2020). Research suggests that such emotionally charged, hedonic experiences strengthen the consumer's connection to the brand and increase their likelihood of engagement, loyalty, and advocacy (Zhang et al., 2024). For instance, a warm chatbot might share enthusiasm about a customer's chosen destination or compliment their travel choices, reinforcing feelings of validation and joy. This emotional immersion encourages customers to spend more time interacting with the chatbot, exploring more options, and ultimately engaging more deeply with the brand. Therefore, we posit the following hypothesis.

H3. The consumer's hedonic involvement with the chatbot positively mediates the relationship between (a) fun and (b) warm chatbot conversation styles and customer engagement.

3.4. Moderation by individualism

Culture is crucial in adopting technology-driven touchpoints (Nam and Kannan, 2021). Individualism is amongst the most frequently explored cultural aspects in marketing for forecasting consumer behaviour (Sivadas et al., 2008). Individualism is associated with the notion of "self," reflecting an individualist perspective (Gupta et al., 2018). Individualists have a self-contained view of themselves that favours novelty, flexibility, free thought, freedom of expression, and uniqueness (Sivadas et al., 2008). They believe in having fun, enjoying themselves, and doing things their way (Nam and Kannan, 2021). Their need for autonomy is strong, focusing on fun, enjoyment, and positive affect. Individualists appreciate environments that promote technological innovation. They evaluate an experience based on their interaction within and across touchpoints the firms in the individual touchpoints, and they expect more to be satisfied (Gupta et al., 2018). Consumers

high on individualism emphasise the prompt and efficient delivery of the service, whereas those low on individualism stress interpersonal communication, courtesy, and compassion in the service delivery process (Gupta et al., 2018). Therefore, we argue that they would prefer a fun chatbot characterised by spontaneity that allows for exploration, experimentation, and improvisation. Furthermore, past research indicates that individualists make judgements based on their personal goals, and when a brand meets those goals and satisfies them, they engage with the brand (Moharana et al., 2023b). They place a higher value on brands and, thus, are more likely to seek validation through brands (Moharana et al., 2023a). Hence, they engage more with the brand due to the high value attached to the brand (Gupta et al., 2018). Also, individualists see their interactions with brands as a trade-off or an exchange (Nam and Kannan, 2021). Therefore, we assert that when consumers high on individualism gain a positive experience from a fun interaction with the chatbot, they will favour a fun chatbot conversation and engage with the brand in exchange. Hence, we advance the following.

H4. Individualism positively moderates the relationship between chatbot conversational style (fun vs. warm) and customer engagement such that the impact of fun (vs. warm) conversational style is accentuated (attenuated) for high (low) individualism.

4. Overview of studies

We tested the theoretical framework (Fig. 1) by employing a survey (study 1) and an experiment (study 2). Study 1 investigated the impact of the chatbot conversational style (fun and warm) on customer engagement (H1a and H1b). It further investigated the underlying mechanism of how chatbot conversation style impacts customer engagement through the customer's sense of liberation (H2) and hedonic involvement (H3). Study 2 examined the impact of fun chatbot conversation styles on customer brand engagement (H1c) compared to traditional warm chatbot conversation styles. It further investigated whether consumer individualism serves as a boundary condition for the relationship between fun (vs. warm) chatbot conversation styles and customer brand engagement (H4).

4.1. Study 1: participants, design, and procedure

The sampling frame of this study included tourists above the age of 18 who have prior experience of resort booking through chatbots. Therefore, the survey started with a question to qualify the respondents for the study. The participants who had experienced chatbot communication for resort booking in the last three months were allowed to complete the survey. 241 U.S. respondents recruited through MTurk participated in an online survey for a compensation of $0.60 each. The survey was created in Qualtrics. The computer program randomised the questions and blocks to eliminate the possibility of common method biases (Podsakoff et al., 2003). It included measures for fun and warmth in chatbot conversation, sense of liberation, hedonic involvement, and customer engagement. Per the suggestion of Roy Bhattacharjee et al. (2023), we incorporated two quality-control questions in the survey to ensure that participants paid attention. Seven participants were eliminated from the study after failing to provide a valid response to these questions. The final useable sample size was 234. The mean age of the sample was 39.4 years, and 42.13 % were female. Approximately 71 % of the participants reported an annual household income of over $80, 000, and 41.6 % had a university education. The sample's representativeness was ensured through prequalification and reporting of text-based chatbot service experience. As we prequalified the respondents, 100 % had prior experience with chatbot services provided by a resort, and over 54 % reported that they had availed of a text-based chatbot service at least twice in the last year. We asked the participants to reflect on their recent communication with a chatbot to book a vacation resort. Next, they were asked to write five to six sentences about their feeling of fun and warmth while conversing with the chatbot.

The participants then responded to items utilised to measure fun and warmth in chatbot conversation, sense of liberation, hedonic involvement, customer engagement, and demographics. The measures of fun, sense of liberation, and hedonic involvement were three-item scales with a 7-point anchor (1 = *Not at all* to 7 = *Very much so*), derived from Oh and Pham (2021). We used a five-item scale (including good-natured, sincere, warm, trustworthy, and tolerant) with a 7-point anchor (1 = *Not at all* to 7 = *Very much so*) to measure warmth in chatbot conversation adapted from Belanche et al. (2021). We measured customer engagement containing cognitive, affective, and behavioural components using a ten-item scale drawing from Hollebeek et al. (2014). The consumer individualism scale was adapted from Sivadas et al. (2008). These items were measured on a 7-point Likert scale (1 = *Strongly disagree* to 7 = *Strongly agree*). For all constructs, we found that the Cronbach alphas were above 0.70.

4.1.1. Measurement model

We examined the overall measurement model using SmartPLS. We preferred partial least squares structural equation modelling (PLS-SEM) over covariance-based SEM (CB-SEM) as our research primarily focuses on initial theory development and prediction for fun-based conversational style (Hair et al., 2021). Compared to CB-SEM, PLS-SEM is more versatile and efficient in prediction with less complex model identification issues (Lv, 2025). Also, PLS-SEM is more suitable for handling complex models using mediation and moderation relationships (Hair et al., 2021). We computed the convergent validity, composite

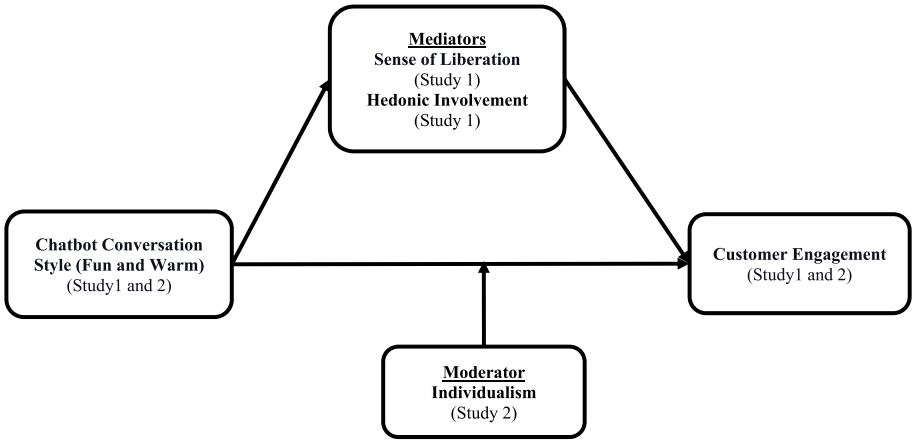


Fig. 1. Overview of studies.

reliability, average variance extracted, and discriminant validity to determine the constructs' psychometric properties (Hair et al., 2021). The standardised loadings were checked for convergent validity to confirm that all variables were above 0.70, and the average variance extracted (AVE) values were greater than 0.50 (Fornell and Larcker, 1981; Hair et al., 2021). The composite reliabilities were higher than the standard benchmark of 0.8. (Fornell and Larcker, 1981). The scale items, factor loadings, Cronbach's Alpha, CR, and AVE values for each construct are listed in Table 2, which demonstrates acceptable convergent validity and reliability.

Additionally, we employed the Fornell and Larcker (1981) criterion to measure discriminant validity, i.e., examining inter-correlations and the square root of average variance extracted (AVE). The square root of the AVE values is greater than the off-diagonal inter-correlation values, supporting discriminant validity (Table 3). Further, results indicated that hetrotrait-monotrait ratio (HTMT) values for all constructs were less than 0.85, hence, acceptable (Table 4). We used a collinearity test to analyse the common method bias (CMB) by evaluating the latent variables' variance inflation factors (VIFs). The VIF scores in our study ranged from 1.636 to 3.112 (below the accepted standard of 3.3), indicating that CMB was not a concern.

4.1.2. Structural model

The magnitude of t-statistics, coefficients of determination (R^2), and Stone-Geisser criteria (Q^2) are all indicators of a model's goodness (Hair et al., 2021). The R^2 values for customer engagement (0.680), sense of liberation (0.539), and hedonic involvement (0.519) indicated that the proposed model had acceptable predictive accuracy (Falk and Miller, 1992). The Q^2 values for customer engagement (0.534), sense of liberation (0.526), and hedonic involvement (0.499) suggested adequate levels of predictive relevance (Hair et al., 2021). We used a bootstrapping procedure employing 5000 subsamples to estimate the t-values and test the hypotheses. The results indicated that the direct effects were positive and significant. Fun (H1a: b = 0.165, t = 2.552, p = 0.011) and warm (H1b: b = 0.152, t = 2.411, p = 0.016) chatbot conversation positively and significantly influenced customer engagement. Similarly, fun chatbot conversation positively and significantly influenced consumer's sense of liberation (b = 0.618, t = 9.983, p = 0.000) and hedonic involvement (b = 0.459, t = 7.147, p = 0.000). We also found positive and significant effects of that warm chatbot conversation on consumers' sense of liberation (b = 0.187, t = 2.572, p = 0.010) and hedonic involvement (b = 0.362, t = 5.021, p = 0.000).

The mediation effects of sense of liberation and hedonic involvement were tested employing a non-parametric bootstrapping procedure using 5000 subsamples to estimate the t-values and the bias-corrected confidence intervals. The proposed indirect effect of fun (H3a: b = 0.209, t = 3.927, p = 0.000) and warm (H3b: b = 0.063, t = 2.025, p = 0.043) chatbot conversations on customer engagement via consumer's sense of liberation was positive and significant. Similarly, the indirect effects of fun (H4a: b = 0.139, t = 2.948, p = 0.003) and warm (H4b: b = 0.109, t = 2.759, p = 0.006) chatbot conversation on customer engagement through consumer's hedonic involvement were positive and significant (Table 5).

4.1.3. Discussion

The study revealed that fun and warm chatbot conversations positively influence consumer brand engagement. It also offers insights into how this occurs through the underlying mechanism of the consumer's sense of liberation and hedonic involvement. Study 1 presented initial support for our H1, H2, and H3. The first study, however, has two major limitations. First, we did not investigate the comparative impact of fun (vs. warm) chatbot conversation styles on customer brand engagement (H1c). Second, we hypothesised (H4) that consumer individualism serves as a boundary condition for the relationship between fun (vs. warm) chatbot conversation styles and customer brand engagement. However, we did not examine it in study 1. We conducted a second study (study 2) to address these limitations.

Table 2
Measurement of Constructs Used in this Study.

Construct and items	Loadings	α	rho_A	CR	AVE
Fun		0.886	0.886	0.929	0.814
How much fun did you have during the chatbot conversation?	0.901				
Were there a lot of fun moments in the chatbot conversation?	0.894				
Was that a fun-filled chatbot conversation?	0.911				
Warm		0.836	0.845	0.884	0.604
The chatbot conversation was mainly good-natured.	0.810				
The chatbot was sincere in its conversation.	0.812				
The chatbot was communicating warmly.	0.757				
I had a trustworthy conversation with the chatbot.	0.806				
The chatbot was tolerant in its conversation.	0.695				
Sense of Liberation (Lib)		0.880	0.883	0.926	0.806
This chatbot conversation enabled me to get away from my worries	0.903				
During this chatbot conversation, I felt liberated	0.915				
I felt carefree during this chatbot conversation	0.875				
Hedonic involvement (HI)		0.814	0.819	0.889	0.728
I felt positively engaged during this overall chatbot conversation	0.864				
Taking all things together, the chatbot conversation was absorbing	0.860				
I felt "in the moment" during this overall chatbot conversation	0.835				
Customer Engagement (CE)		0.935	0.936	0.945	0.632
Using this resort brand, Relaxury, will get me to think about it	0.809				
I would think about this resort brand, Relaxury, a lot when I'm using it.	0.804				
Using this resort brand, Relaxury, would stimulate my interest to learn more about the brand.	0.806				
I would feel very positive when I use this resort brand, Relaxury.	0.837				
Using this resort brand, Relaxury, would make me happy.	0.776				
I would feel good when I use this resort brand, Relaxury.	0.809				
I'll be proud to use this resort brand, Relaxury.	0.787				
I would spend a lot of time using this resort brand, Relaxury, compared to other resort brands.	0.768				
Whenever I'm using a resort, I usually use Relaxury.	0.770				
This brand is one of the brands I would use when I use a resort.	0.783				

Note: α denotes Cronbach alpha, CR denotes Composite reliability, and AVE represents average variance extracted.

4.2. Study 2: participants, design, and procedure

A sampling frame of tourists who were visiting a pre-selected destination was used for this study. A top-of-the-mind recall pre-test

Table 3
Discriminant validity assessment.

Fornell–Larcker criterion	CE	Fun	Warm	HE	Liberation
CE	**0.795**				
Fun	0.687	**0.902**			
HI	0.738	0.653	**0.853**		
Liberation	0.746	0.717	0.695	**0.898**	
Warm	0.599	0.535	0.607	0.517	**0.777**

Note. The square root of the average variance extracted for each construct is reported in bold along the diagonal. CE denotes customer engagement, and HI denotes hedonic involvement. All correlations were significant at $p < 0.01$.

Table 4
Heterotrait–Monotrait ratio (HTMT).

Constructs	CE	Fun	Warm	HE	Liberation
CE					
Fun	0.754				
HI	0.841	0.763			
Liberation	0.821	0.812	0.816		
Warm	0.663	0.607	0.725	0.583	

Table 5
Structural model results (study 1).

Path	Path Coefficient	t-value	P Values/95 % CI
H1a: Fun → CE	0.165	2.552	**
H1b: Warm → CE	0.152	2.411	**
H2a: Fun → Liberation → CE	0.209	3.927	*** [0.116, 0.326]
H2b: Warm → Liberation → CE	0.063	2.025	* [0.016, 0.135]
H3a: Fun →HI →CE	0.139	2.948	** [0.058, 0.241]
H3b: Warm →HI →CE	0.109	2.759	** [0.043, 0.198]

Note: *p < 0.05, **p < 0.01, ***p < 0.001. CE denotes customer engagement, HI denotes hedonic involvement, CI denote confidence interval.

(Pradhan et al., 2023) was carried out among 27 (11 women) employees of a reputed university in India (Average age = 34 years) who had visited at least two destinations in the last five years. The pre-test results generated 42 unique destinations. Finally, the destination selected for data collection was Mahabalipuram, Chennai, which had the highest recall frequency in the pre-test. Two of the authors visited the chosen destination for data collection. The respondents were requested to participate in the study voluntarily in front of a water park. We selected the final sample using a systematic random sampling design wherein every third customer coming to the water park was requested to be a respondent. The respondents voluntarily participated in this study in exchange for a coupon worth $3 that can be exchanged to get an entry pass for the water park. We approached 150 respondents. Similar to Study 1, two quality-control questions were asked, as indicated by Roy Bhattacharjee et al. (2023), to ensure that participants were paying attention. The survey started with a question to qualify the respondents for the study. The participants who had experienced chatbot communication for resort booking in the last three months were recruited to complete the survey. Thirty-seven respondents were eliminated from the study after failing to provide a valid response to these questions. A total of 113 respondents (M_{age} = 34.5 years; 32.7 per cent female) finally participated in the study. 53 % of the sample reported an annual household income of more than ₹10, 00, 000 (approximately $11,600), and 32.4 % were university graduates. The sample's representativeness was ensured through prequalification and reporting of text-based chatbot service experience. As we prequalified the respondents, 100 % of them had prior experience of hotel booking through chatbot services, and over 79 % reported that they had availed of a text-based chatbot service at least two times in the last year. This experiment employed a single-factor between-subjects design (chatbot conversation style: fun vs. warm).

We designed two contrasting scenarios with chatbots communicating in fun vs. warm conversation styles on behalf of a fictitious hotel brand named *Relaxury*. We showed the participants a video of an actual chatbot-consumer conversation to make it more engaging and appear real. The participants took part in a task that required them to seek information and book a vacation resort named *Relaxury*. They visited Relaxury's website and connected with Alice, their chatbot. Alice provides information regarding their reservation at the *Relaxury* resort. The participants read the following instructions:

> "*Imagine you were to book a holiday for yourself and your loved ones at a resort named Relaxury. You went to Relaxury's website, and you got to connect with Alice, their chatbot. Alice assists you with any questions you may have about your reservation at the Relaxury resort*".

Next, the participants were presented with one of the two stimuli, i.e., the chatbot conversation videos, instantiating fun or warm conversation styles. Based on Oh and Pham (2021), this study designed a fun chatbot conversation-style video to elicit fun in the conversation. We used light-hearted words, such as "Ahoy there!", "Yippee!", "Awesome" along with fun-inducing emojis. Similarly, we took cues from Roy and Naidoo (2021) to make the video representing the warm chatbot conversation style to elicit warmth, containing elements of friendliness and care. For warm condition, we used friendly and professional words such as "Hello", "Sure sir", and "Great" and regularly used emojis (see Appendix 1). The stimuli are pre-tested among 34 corporate executives (Mage = 34.6 years, 23.53 % female) attending a training program. The analysis of variance (ANOVA) indicated successful manipulation (fun condition: $M_{fun} = 5.63$ vs $M_{warm} = 3.61$, $F_{(1,33)} = 21.97$, $p = 0.00$) and warm condition: $M_{warm} = 5.44$ vs $M_{fun} = 3.44$, $F_{(1,33)} = 22.57$, $p = 0.00$). We found non-significant confounding effects for individual message length ($p > 0.57$), overall conversation length ($p > 0.87$) and chatbot familiarity ($p > 0.86$). After watching the video, participants answered the following manipulation check questions - "The chatbot was fun" and "The chatbot was warm" (Oh and Pham, 2021) and rated for scenario realism. We controlled for the relevance and helpfulness of the chatbot (Van den Broeck et al., 2019), which might provide an alternative explanation. We used three-item scales for relevance and helpfulness adapted from Van den Broeck et al. (2019). We collected data for control variables such as chatbot familiarity and tech-savviness of the respondents through single-item scales. Next, based on that chatbot-consumer conversation, participants answered how they would engage with the resort brand *Relaxury*. It captured the key dependent variable of the study, i.e., customer brand engagement, using a ten-item scale adapted from Hollebeek et al. (2014). The moderating variable, individualism, was measured on a pre-established 14-item scale (Sivadas et al., 2008). A median split was done on the averaged individualism scale, indicating low individualism as 0 and high individualism as 1. A seven-point Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree and 7 = strongly agree) was used for all the multi-item scales, and the Cronbach alpha for all constructs ranged between 0.76 and 0.92.

4.2.1. Results

These results of one-way ANOVA confirmed a successful manipulation for perceived fun and warm conversation style conditions. Perceived fun was significantly higher in the fun condition than in the warm condition ($M_{fun} = 5.52$ vs $M_{warm} = 3.72$, $F_{(1,112)} = 54.68$, $p = 0.00$). Similarly, perceived warmth was significantly higher in the warm condition than in the fun condition ($M_{warm} = 5.30$ vs $M_{fun} = 3.25$, $F_{(1,112)} = 64.98$, $p = 0.00$). The stimuli did not differ significantly on perceptions of helpfulness ($M_{fun} = 5.34$ vs $M_{warm} = 5.06$, $F_{(1,112)} = 1.43$, $p = 0.23$) and relevance ($M_{fun} = 5.13$ vs $M_{warm} = 4.84$, $F_{(1,112)} = 2.03$, $p = 0.16$).

An initial data analysis using ANOVA included respondents' age, chatbot familiarity, and tech-savviness as covariates to check the confounding effects. We found non-significant effects ($p > 0.5$) of all control

variables; therefore, we removed them from further analysis of the data (Moharana et al., 2023b). A one-way ANOVA revealed a significant effect of the chatbot's conversation style ($F_{(1,112)} = 21.12$, $p = 0.00$) on customer engagement. The fun chatbot conversation ($M_{fun} = 5.00$) resulted in greater customer engagement than the warm chatbot conversation ($M_{warm} = 4.36$). Next, we ran a two-way ANOVA to test the interaction effects of chatbot conversation style (fun vs. warm) and customers' individualism (high vs. low) on customer engagement. The results showed a significant two-way interaction ($F_{(1,109)} = 5.50$, $p = 0.02$). Thus, H4 was supported (Fig. 2). The manipulations of fun (vs warm) conversation style had a non-significant effect on helpfulness ($F_{(1,112)} = 1.43$, $p > 0.05$), ruling out any alternative explanation to the manipulations. Table 6 summarises these results.

4.2.2. Discussion

The findings of Study 2 show that fun (vs warm) chatbot conversations positively influence customer engagement with the brand, such that the effect is stronger in the case of a fun chatbot. Furthermore, we test the boundary condition for chatbot conversation style-customer brand engagement relationships. As expected, our findings show that consumers high on individualism engage more (less) with the brand when exposed to a fun (vs. warm) chatbot conversation style.

5. General discussion

The present investigation began with the research question of whether the fun conversation style of a chatbot elicits better customer engagement than a warm conversation style. Through Study 1, this research demonstrated that both conversational styles of chatbots – fun and warm-significantly increase customer engagement. Study 1 further demonstrated the psychological mechanisms (hedonic involvement and sense of liberation) underlying the relationship between fun conversational style and customer engagement. Study 2, in an experimental design and with a diverse sample, showed that a fun conversational style generates better engagement than a warm conversational style. Customers are more engaged when they have fun interactions with chatbots than warm interactions, which engender cognitive, emotional, and behavioural engagement with the brand (Rohit et al., 2024). This extends the existing literature on the effectiveness of chatbots in service settings, which has examined only two different chatbot conversational styles – warm and competent specifically to date. Further, study 2 showed that the cultural orientation of individualism accentuates the relationship between chatbot conversation and customer engagement when the conversational style is fun (vs warm).

5.1. Theoretical implications

The finding of this research demonstrated that a fun conversational style, compared to a warm conversational style, would engender greater customer engagement. We contribute to the literature on customer engagement and research related to chatbots by demonstrating how chatbots' fun conversations can improve customer service encounters and assist customers in their decision-making. Our findings demonstrate that the effectiveness of fun chatbots can be attributed to their ability to make customer experiences enjoyable, which in turn fosters engagement (Hoyer et al., 2020). One key takeaway from our research is that fun is essential in technology adoption. Thus, firms should leverage fun in self-service technologies to create positive consumer experiences and behaviours (Niu and Mvondo, 2024).

This research corroborates customer's psychological theory of consumer fun by testing the relationship between chatbot conversational style and customer engagement (Oh and Pham, 2021). It empirically validates and echoes the suggestions of Prentice et al. (2020) that firms should employ strategies to increase fun in the interactions of virtual conversational agents with customers, enhancing customer engagement. Next, we provide insights into the antecedents of customer engagement and technology-enabled factors that drive customer engagement. This research contributes significantly to the emergent paradigm of technology-enabled service by linking it with customer engagement research. It demonstrates novel ways in which chatbots can handle customer relationships and foster customer engagement (Prentice et al., 2020).

This research also uncovers underlying psychological mechanisms through which a fun chatbot conversation drives customer engagement. Fun chatbots provide consumers with an escape or feelings of liberation from boredom. Our findings further show that when consumers interact with fun chatbots, their need for liberation or escape and their hedonic needs are fulfilled. These findings resonate with extant literature evidence that scientists should look beyond utilitarian benefits while designing chatbots. We extend this by specifically showing the role of a fun conversational style in fostering customer engagement. This aligns with a stream of research that advocates for chatbot attributes that can stimulate hedonic involvement (Fatima et al., 2024). In doing so, we contribute to the psychological theory of consumer fun (Oh and Pham, 2021) by uncovering the underlying psychological mechanism.

Furthermore, customer engagement is understudied in terms of how it varies with cultures (Nam and Kannan, 2021). We respond to these specific calls to investigate whether and how cultural aspects moderate the influence of virtual agents on customer engagement and their decision-making. Individualists engage in multi-channel consumption and evaluate their experiences based on their interaction across multiple touch points (Gupta et al., 2018). Our research contributes to this discourse by demonstrating how individualists interact with chatbots in their consumption process. Specifically, it offers fresh perspectives into how consumers differ in terms of individualism and how this influences the choice of chatbot conversational style and customer engagement. We explain it plausibly by asserting that individualists evaluate their experience based on the accumulation of conversations across various

Table 6
Summary of results (study 2).

Hypothesis	Type	Test	Results	Conclusion
H1c: Chatbot conversation style: Fun (vs. warm)→ customer engagement	Main effects	One way ANOVA	$M_{Fun} = 5.00$; $M_{Warm} = 4.36$. $F_{(1,112)} = 21.12$, $p = 0.00$	Supported
H2: 2 (Chatbot conversation style: Fun vs. Warm) × 2 (Individualism: High vs Low) → customer engagement	Moderation effects	Two-way ANOVA	$F_{(1,109)} = 5.50$, $p = 0.02$	Supported

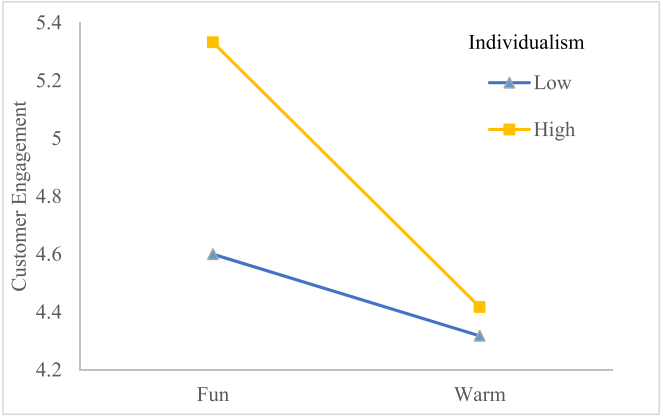


Fig. 2. Interaction Effect (Conversation Style x individualism).

touchpoints (Gupta et al., 2018). Thus, they structure their decisions on individual goals; when fun chatbots can meet them, they engage with the brands. Therefore, extending prior research (Thompson and Brouthers, 2021), our study demonstrates that individualistic customers respond favourably to fun appeals in marketing communications.

5.2. Practical implications

Recently, chatbots are adopted as conversational agents to improve service operations and customer engagement. Chatbots now manage customer inquiries and execute transactions in several industries, such as restaurants, airline companies, and online retail. At the same time, chatbots sometimes fall short of customer expectations, causing frustration and negatively impacting customers' overall experience and satisfaction with the firm (Crolic et al., 2021). Firms must configure chatbots that can communicate with customers persuasively, meet their expectations, and enhance their level of engagement. This is crucial since customer engagement is associated with corporate performance, including financial and non-financial results (Prentice et al., 2020). Thus, firms should make necessary chatbot design-related interventions.

Our findings assert that chatbots must adopt a fun conversational style while communicating with customers in a service encounter (Park, 2020). Fun stimulates customers' attention, interest, arousal, and curiosity (Kim and Song, 2020). Fun chatbots have elements of novelty, social connectedness, and spontaneity. To enhance customer engagement, we recommend marketers and chatbot designers cultivate a quirky chatbot persona that facilitates light-hearted and fun conversations. This can be achieved through the strategic use of emojis or memes. For example, travel and tourism companies, such as MakeMyTrip, have employed chatbots that often use catchy emojis in their conversations. Therefore, our findings provide actionable insights for hotel managers and customer experience designers looking to enhance customer engagement through chatbot interactions. While the traditional "warm" conversational style is widely adopted across industries, it may not fully capitalise on the potential of engaging customers in a more enjoyable way. Fun conversational styles, as our research shows, have the potential to differentiate hotel brands by creating a sense of liberation and hedonic involvement. Currently, many hotel chatbots aim for a warm tone, seeking to replicate the courteous, human-like qualities of customer service representatives. However, few have explored or implemented playful, humorous styles that align with the brand's personality. For instance, a luxury hotel brand could include subtle wit in its chatbot interactions to maintain sophistication while still being engaging. On the other hand, a budget-friendly hotel chain might use light-hearted puns, emojis, or even jokes to reflect an approachable and youthful brand identity. Incorporating such playful elements into chatbot language creates a unique brand voice and increases the likelihood of memorable and enjoyable interactions, leading to higher customer engagement.

Our findings also reveal that a fun chatbot conversation increases customers' sense of liberation, positively influencing customer engagement with brands. Therefore, our study demonstrates the importance of instilling a sense of liberation in consumers through fun chatbots. If chatbot conversations are framed as a "break" or "escape" from the usual, they will be perceived as more fun, leading to increased customer brand engagement. Further, the study reveals that customers' hedonic involvement— the pleasure and satisfaction derived from the chatbot experience—mediates the impact of fun and warm conversational styles on customer engagement. This suggests that even brands with a more traditionally warm and supportive tone could enhance engagement by incorporating subtle, pleasurable elements. Providing users with options to personalise chatbot interactions can foster a stronger sense of connection and satisfaction, aligning with hedonic enjoyment and a sense of liberation. Therefore, we propose actionable strategies to help practitioners effectively implement a fun conversational style. First, hotel managers can consider integrating humour or creativity into chatbot responses. For example, instead of a standard "Your room is ready," a fun chatbot might say, "Your home-away-from-home is set—bring on the vacation vibes!" Similarly, incorporating surprise-and-delight elements, like interactive mini-games or quirky GIFs when confirming bookings, can humanise the interaction and create a sense of joy. Second, we recommend conducting A/B testing to evaluate the impact of a fun conversational style on metrics such as booking completion rates, customer satisfaction scores, and time spent on the platform. This allows businesses to fine-tune the balance between playfulness and professionalism based on data-driven insights. Third, practitioners should ensure that chatbot design aligns with the target audience and cultural context. For instance, while younger audiences might appreciate a highly playful tone, older or international audiences may prefer subtle humour.

The findings further suggest that adopting a fun conversational style in chatbots could enhance engagement, particularly when catering to customers who value individualism. Practically, this implies that brands might benefit from creating chatbots with playful, light-hearted tones that encourage a sense of pleasure and enjoyment during the interaction. Such an approach can be particularly effective in markets where individualism is a prominent cultural trait, as users in these contexts are likely to respond better to fun. For global companies, it may be beneficial to localise chatbot styles to align with cultural variations in individualism, thereby optimising the engagement potential of fun and warm conversational tones. By strategically balancing these conversational styles and tailoring them to cultural values, brands can maximise the effectiveness of their chatbots and create a compelling, memorable user experience.

6. Limitations and future research directions

This study has certain limitations that future research can address. First, we acknowledge that this study assessed only the impact of fun and warm conversational styles on customer engagement. Therefore, we suggest future scholars investigate other styles and their relative influence, such as the impact of fun versus competent chatbot conversational styles, formal vs. informal conversational styles (Li and Wang, 2023) and task-oriented vs. social-oriented styles (Xu et al., 2023) on customer engagement. Such explorations will provide a more comprehensive understanding of how different chatbot communication styles impact customer interaction and engagement. Second, we used tourist samples from the U.S. with prior resort booking experience (Study 1) and Indian tourists visiting a single pre-selected destination (Study 2). While this sampling approach provides useful insights into the target audience, the findings may not be generalisable to other tourist populations or non-tourist chatbot users. Future research could extend the sampling frame to include a more diverse range of participants to enhance generalizability. Third, the development of the chatbot scenarios was based on two distinct conversational styles. While these scenarios were carefully designed to reflect realistic interactions, they may not fully capture the complexity and variability of real-world chatbot conversations. Personal biases or prior experiences might have influenced respondents' interactions with the chatbot, potentially limiting the applicability of the results. Future research could incorporate more nuanced and dynamic scenarios to address this limitation. Fourth, this study is limited to tourism, where we compared fun and warm conversational styles in chatbots. Although chatbots provide comparable functions, chatbots' conversational styles might have different impacts in specific contexts. For example, a chatbot that forecasts stock market trends should be more competent than funny. Similarly, a chatbot providing healthcare advice might prioritise warmth and empathy over fun, whereas retail brands can deploy chatbots that offer fun and interesting experiences through novel ideas, looks and designs (Moharana and Pattanaik, 2023). Therefore, we call upon future research to extend these investigations by examining the impact of fun chatbot conversational styles on customer behaviour in other domains,

such as retail, education, healthcare and others. Fifth, this research focuses on improving customer interactions by substituting humans with chatbots. However, future researchers can examine the potential of other AI-based technologies in augmenting customer engagement. Specifically, the psychological theory of consumer fun could explain how virtual agents, such as Amazon's Alexa or Google Assistant, can stimulate customer engagement if designed in a novel, spontaneous, and socially connected manner. Sixth, this study assessed the cultural factor of individualism as a boundary condition on the chatbot conversation style-customer engagement relationship. Future scholars can explore the impact of situational variables and consumer characteristics as possible moderators impacting these relationships.

7. Conclusion

Chatbots have become a vital tool for customer service in the tourism industry, and marketers use them to interact with customers (Carvalho and Ivanov, 2024). Our findings underscore how crucial it is for the tourism industry to provide immersive services through technology integration, especially through creative chatbot conversations, to build lasting relationships with customers. By examining the effects of a novel "fun" chatbot conversational style, we offer fresh perspectives on how technology and customer engagement interact. Our results also highlight the importance of considering cultural values like individualism into account when developing and implementing chatbots to maintain customer engagement. Additionally, our study makes a substantial contribution to the ongoing discussion on customer engagement in today's fast-paced business. In sum, we propose that businesses can greatly improve the efficacy of their chatbot conversations by carefully tailoring them to particular expectations and striking a balance between fun and warm conversational styles. Such an approach strengthens customer relationships and drives business success.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Debashree Roy Bhattacharjee: Writing – original draft, Validation, Software, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Abhisek Kuanr:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Resources, Methodology, Investigation, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Debasis Pradhan:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Supervision, Methodology, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Tapas Ranjan Moharana:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Methodology, Formal analysis, Conceptualization.

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Declaration of competing interest

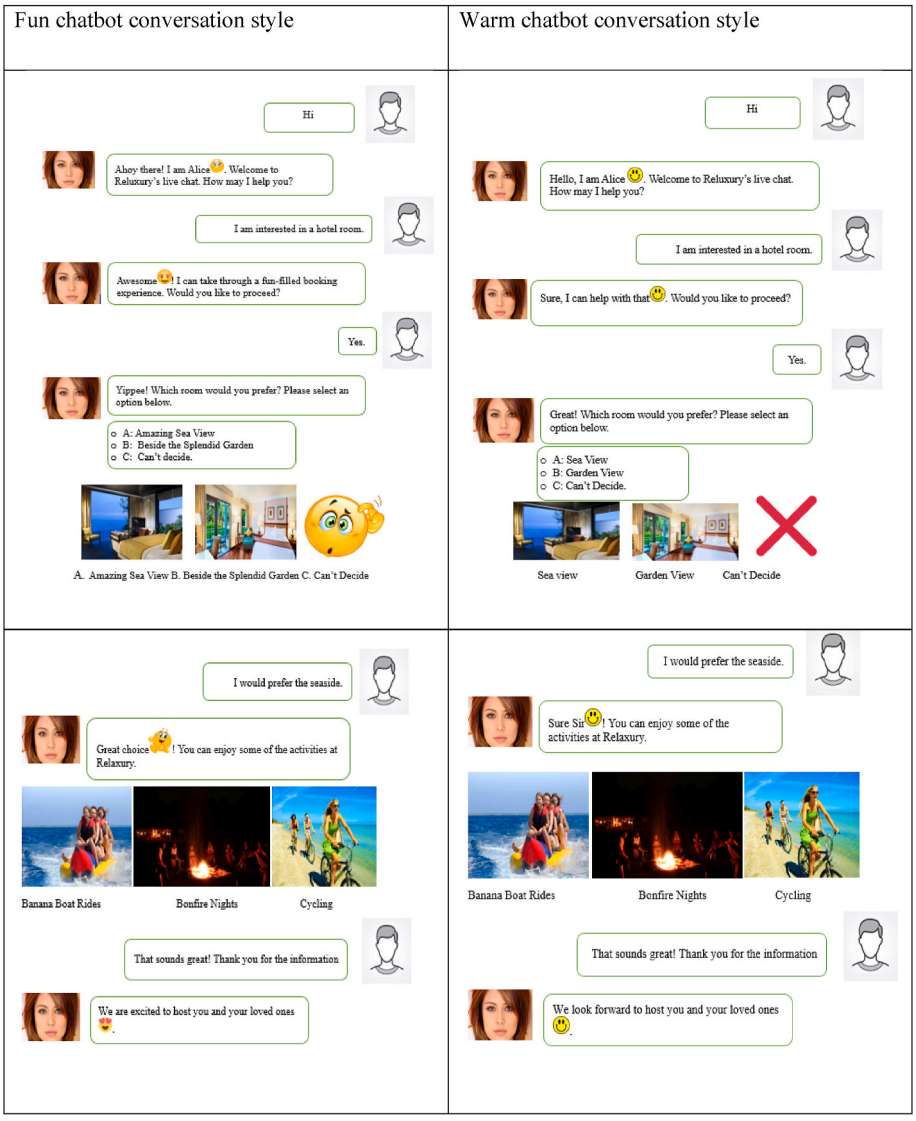
We declare that we have no conflicts of interest to disclose.

Acknowledgement

All contributors to the study are listed as authors.

Appendix 1

Chatbot Conversation Stimuli.



Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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